

Trend Micro 'droided

Trend Micro takes charge of 'droid security by safeguarding the Android platform for Mobiles and Tablets <http://dgit.in/trendmican>



Street view flashback

A new update to Google's Street View lets you now view the changes made to a place in the course of time. <http://dgit.in/StreetFlash>

Agent 001

something a bit more powerful, get one that's powered by an i3 CPU. If you need a good all-rounder, get a device with an i5 and an Nvidia GPU. Obviously, if your budget permits it, get yourself an i7 and a more powerful Nvidia GPU and you should be all set for at least two years of computing pleasure.

AMD: If you're willing to sacrifice some amount of CPU power and battery power for better graphics performance, then AMD's APUs are made for you. You'll identify these CPUs by the "A" before their model no. (like the AMD A6).

For those not in the know, an APU is essentially an AMD GPU that's been mated to an AMD CPU. In effect what you get is a hybrid CPU-GPU combo that offers you something less than the best of both worlds. Take the case of the A10 APU, when pitted against an i5 (in the same price bracket) it offers you the computational power of a Celeron M and GPU power that's about 30% below what you'd get from an Nvidia 640M. That said, the combination works quite well, especially in GPU intensive applications, but there are very few other scenarios where you'd appreciate the APU.

Another main drawback of the APU is the tremendous loss in battery life, which is about half of what you'd get with an i5, and easily 7 times lower than what you'd get from a Celeron. AMD's E1, which is their low-end APU, is a bad choice for budget laptops though and even though the graphics option (on paper) is better than that on the competing Celeron, know that no amount of graphical power can compensate for loss in processing power.

RAM

The easiest decision you'll ever make, just remember that the more RAM you have the better your PC will perform. Don't take any laptop that sports anything lower than 2GB of RAM and 4GB is what I'd recommend as a starting point. While Windows can function on 1GB of RAM, you will be hard-pressed to get the rest of your apps working optimally. In fact, with even 2GB of RAM, a browser such as Google Chrome will be unbearably slow with even 10 tabs open.



Monitor

Don't scrimp on this. Your laptop will be with you for the duration of its working life (probably) and the monitor will be what you'll be staring at during that time. Get a good monitor, spend a little extra if you must but do not compromise on this. You'll regret your decision later.

The screen size is entirely your decision. Just remember that a larger screen size means lower battery life and a heavier laptop.

Storage

If you want battery life and performance, then an SSD in your laptop is a must. For anything else, just go with a storage capacity that you're comfortable with. Don't spend too much on an upgraded HDD though, usually the cost-



per-GB is very high for a manufacturer upgrade and you'll find that it's more economical to just purchase a portable HDD separately.

Keyboard and Touchpad

As with the monitor, this is something you'll spend interacting with the most. There's no right or wrong choice really in terms of layout, just go with the one that suits you best. However, a comfortable

keyboard is much more important than a convenient layout. Layouts you can get used to. But sticky keys? Never.

I've found that most laptops do offer decent keyboards these days, but I do tend to recommend Lenovo Thinkpads to anyone who wants a device primarily for typing on. It's not that HP or Sony or any other company are bad, but personally, Lenovo's island keys just seem more comfortable.



Essentials

Other essentials on any laptop that you must look out for are USB3.0 ports, HDMI output, an SD card reader and a webcam. These are usually present by default but the number of available USB ports might matter to a lot of people, so do count them.

It's hard to give a straight-up recommendation when it comes good audio from a laptop, but I've noticed that Sony laptops do tend to have the best audio quality around. The speakers on HP laptops are usually not that bad.

To conclude

If you'll notice, I've refrained from giving you any sort of recommendation with regards to laptop models and budgets. The reasoning for this is simple, laptops are constantly upgraded so what is relevant today may not be as relevant 30 days from now and also, this guide is meant to arm you with the knowledge necessary to find your dream laptop. I shall keep you updated with the ebb and flow of the tide of technology. Hopefully, though, I've finally taught you how to fish, for laptops at the very least.

Do drop me a mail at agent001@thinkdigit.com if you need some more advice or assistance.